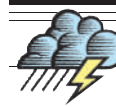


The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

RE V1 V2 V3 V4



T-storm, windy 63/32 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny, windy 42/25 C8

Democracy Dies in Darkness

SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 16, 2025 • \$6

‘Hardball’ tack fueled Trump win on Cabinet

Cajoling, coercion got handful of GOP senators to ‘yes’ on nominees

BY HANNAH KNOWLES, JACQUELINE ALEMANY AND LIZ GOODWIN

When Donald Trump announced in the fall that he wanted then-congressman Matt Gaetz to become attorney general, Republican senators made clear they would not confirm the widely disliked figure who faced sexual misconduct allegations.

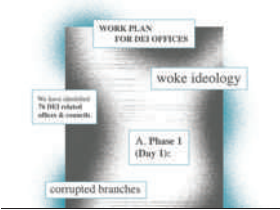
But that early sign of resistance — which led Gaetz to withdraw — quickly faded. GOP senators are on track to confirm all of Trump’s Cabinet nominees and have mostly swallowed their concerns.

The triumph of Trump’s most controversial picks has set the tone for the president’s domineering relationship with Congress — and left allies more confident than ever that he can have his way in Washington.

“The lesson we take away today is that Gaetz could have been saved,” MAGA influencer and former Trump adviser Stephen K. Bannon said.

Pete Hegseth, Trump’s choice for defense secretary, was narrowly confirmed, with the support of all but three GOP senators, despite allegations of sexual misconduct and alcohol abuse that he denied. All but one Republican voted to confirm him.

SEE CABINET ON A6



Documents detail step-by-step plans by the U.S. DOGE Service to purge federal agencies of diversity, equity and inclusion workers and offices. Here’s what comes next. **Pages A8-9**



DUSTIN CHAMBERS/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Phenix Lumber Co., where workers have lost fingers, broken bones and been mangled. In recent years, three workers died.

America’s deadliest worksite — for years

OSHA issued over 180 citations and millions in fines to an Alabama sawmill, but the mayhem didn’t stop

BY TODD C. FRANKEL
IN PHENIX CITY, ALA.

The police lieutenant sounded unnerved as he stepped inside the old lumber mill. The power was off. The giant saws were quiet. But the smell of fresh sawdust still hung in the humid summer air. In the darkened factory, sunlight streamed through jagged holes in the rusted metal walls as Lt. Marc Cutt walked across a machine that turned logs into lumber.

“Has it been rendered safe?” Cutt asked another police officer as his body camera recorded the scene.

“Safe is a relative term in this place,” the officer responded.

The police knew this place well. So did federal safety inspectors.



OBTAINED BY THE WASHINGTON POST

A body-cam image taken as police responded to the 2023 death of James Streetman, 67, who fell into a giant auger.

At Phenix Lumber Co., workers had lost fingers, broken bones and been mangled by machines — at least 28 employees had reported injuries since 2010, at a company with only about 50 people on the payroll at a time. Three had died. A medical examiner’s report detailed how just 23 pounds of one employee was recovered after he was caught in a machine. It had reached the point, some former workers said, that they would pray before the start of their \$9-an-hour shifts.

Phenix Lumber was the deadliest workplace in America over the past five years. No other office or factory posted a higher rate of work-related fatal incidents per worker, according to a

SEE OSHA ON A12

Bird flu fight takes big bite out of egg farmers’ wallets

Industry spends millions trying to prevent disease from devastating flocks

BY SHANNON NAJMA BADI

They’ve installed “biosecurity truck washes” and employee showers. They sanitize visitors’ tires, blast noise cannons, or play predatory bird calls to scare off wild waterfowl that carry the virus.

The egg industry is shelling out millions of dollars as farms try to prevent bird flu amid an outbreak that has no end in sight. Avian influenza has killed more than 150 million birds in the United States since 2022, leading to chicken and egg shortages that have prompted grocers to limit shoppers’ egg-carton purchases and restaurants to add surcharges for omelets.

While egg prices have reached

record highs for consumers, farmers say they have to spend large sums to keep their hens healthy. “We’re in the fight of our lives,” said Sam Krouse, co-chief executive of MPS Egg Farms, which says it has spent \$12 million on biosecurity measures since 2015.

It’s not clear how much the egg industry as a whole has spent on biosecurity in recent years. Some farmers and equipment suppliers said demand increased significantly after a bird flu outbreak in 2015 and again with the current surge, which began in 2022.

“There [were] a lot of firms that said ‘I cannot lose my farm,’” said Keith Bailey, with Hydro-Chem Systems, a manufacturer of truck wash equipment and detergent that’s seen its farmer inquiries at least double each year since 2022.

Preventive steps can be expensive, but failure is worse, farmers say. If one bird tests positive for influenza, the entire flock,

SEE FARMS ON A19

A grueling task of clearing scorched debris, toxic waste

EPA scrambles in a tight, Trump-imposed timeline to help L.A. residents eager to rebuild

BY RUBY MELLEN



BARBARA DAVIDSON/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Margot Stueber, right, weeps as she watches what’s left of her Altadena home be demolished.

ALTADENA, CALIF. — It’s been over a month since Margot Stueber’s house was destroyed in the Eaton Fire, but on a sunny Tuesday in this neighborhood, where entire blocks have been reduced to rubble, she felt like she was saying goodbye all over again.

The 68-year-old psychotherapist watched through sunglasses, her shock of purple-dyed hair wafting in the wind, as workers operating massive vehicles marked a new phase in Los Angeles’s fire recovery operations, by slowly beginning to clear the rubble of what was once Stueber’s beloved cottage.

“It’s a rite of passage,” she said. “A rite of passage is not necessarily something that doesn’t hurt.”

Like Stueber, many Los Angeles residents stricken by loss are eager to transition to a new phase of recovery: clearing the rubble so they can rebuild. Federal, state and local workers have been toiling for weeks.

SEE RECOVERY ON A18

METRO
DEI cuts will hurt training for teachers at schools in need, educators say.

BOOK WORLD
The past year has yielded a barrage of meditations on divorce.



ARTS & STYLE
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BUSINESS
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SPORTS
Reflecting on 5 decades of pain, joy, comfort and love with the Capitals.

TRAVEL
Civil rights giant Pauli Murray gets their due at this social justice center.

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